Three First Moves for a Family That Has Time

Where to begin with Mom's care picture, and what can wait.

Mom is doing fine, mostly. Nothing has happened, and you'd still like a few things written down while the week is quiet.

Here are three places to begin, in order. None of them has a deadline.

1

Ask Mom to walk you through an ordinary week

Pick an easy moment, over coffee or on the way back from an errand, and ask what a normal week looks like for her: mornings, the middle of the day, evenings. Ask her; don't announce that the family is getting organized. Jot it down in her words. AARP's planning guide says the most important part of a conversation like this is to listen. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The best source on Mom's week is Mom, and starting with her keeps her in charge of her own story.

2

List the help that's already there

Write down everyone who does something for her, however small: your sister's Thursday drive to appointments, the neighbor who brings in the mail, the Wednesday night phone call. Beside each name, put what they do and how often. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests that anyone who helps make a list of what they do, for their own clarity and for family members who may not be aware of it. [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST None of it feels like caregiving to the people doing it, so it rarely gets said out loud. With Mom's week in front of you, it's easy to spot.

3

Agree when the family will look at it again

Put your notes on one page, tell the family where it's kept, and choose what will bring you back to it: a date, or an everyday change such as a new medicine or a change in who helps. The CDC suggests updating a written care plan every year, or sooner after a change in health or medicines. A family's page can borrow that rhythm. [3]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST A page is only useful if people can find it and know when to update it. With the date named now, nobody has to raise the subject from scratch next time.

What can wait

- Any question of whether Mom needs more help, or less. This page doesn't ask it.
- Anything about where she lives.
- Who in the family should do what in the years ahead.
- Hearing from every relative. A few lines from one or two is enough to begin.
- The gaps. Where nobody knows, write “not yet known” and leave it for later.

If the first conversation is short

That's fine. AARP's guide says a conversation like this will likely take place over time, so write down what Mom did say and pick it up another day. There is no clock on any of this.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say how Mom is managing or whether anything should change. It gives a family with time three places to begin, in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've heard Mom describe her week, listed the help around her and picked a time to look again. The care interview goes further: it asks about her daily life one area at a time, including the parts nobody thought to mention, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Listening first, and letting the conversation take its time, follow AARP's planning guide. The list of who does what follows the Family Caregiver Alliance. The yearly review follows the CDC's guidance on written care plans, which we've borrowed for a family's page. The order is ours.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving 101: On Being a Caregiver
3. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan

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From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.